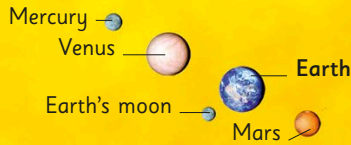


The solar system

The solar system is the name given to our immediate neighbourhood in space. It is made up of a star (the Sun), eight planets, more than 170 moons, and an assortment of comets, asteroids, and other space rocks and dust. All of these are held captive by the Sun's gravity.



Inner planets

The asteroid belt (made up of millions of rocky bodies) circles the Sun. Mercury, Venus, Earth, and Mars are on the inner side of the belt.

What's in a name?

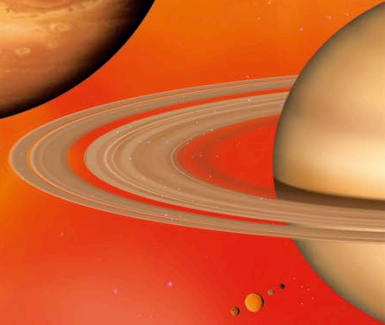
Most of the planets were named after Roman gods: Mercury is the winged messenger (because it appears to move swiftly); Venus is named after the goddess of love (because it is the brightest and is considered the most beautiful planet); Mars is the god of war (because of its red, blood-like colour); Jupiter is named after the king of the gods (it is the largest planet); Saturn is the father of Jupiter and the god of agriculture; Uranus is the Greek god of the sky; and Neptune is the Roman god of the sea (named after its colour).

The planets circle, or orbit, the Sun,
spinning as they move.



Jupiter

Jupiter has more than 60 moons. The largest four (Ganymede, Callisto, Io, and Europa) can be seen from the Earth through binoculars.



Outer planets

The planets outside of the asteroid belt are Jupiter, Saturn, Uranus, and Neptune. Pluto used to be the most distant planet, but it failed the new planet test (opposite), and is now known as a dwarf planet.